policy exchanges that bring about greater strategic comfort. In short, diplomacy supports, empowers and facilitates the national security effort.

Some of this happens on the domestic side as well, even if it is less obvious. Peace at home has often been troubled by insurgent groups operating from the neighbourhood. Adept diplomacy, however, has effectively discouraged neighbours from providing shelter or support. From time to time, it has taken a little more than that to achieve results. That, too, has been persuasively justified.

Separatism, violence and fundamentalism have also been propagated from destinations afar, misusing the protections of free speech. Canada and the UK have both witnessed such happenings. These also require vigorous and continuous countering, since some see preaching violence against others not to be in discordance with democratic rights. Where arguments and persuasion yield little result, firmer diplomatic measures may also be required. Our overall posture does radiate the message that India will no longer be a punching bag in the politics of others.

Arguments must be met with reason, but polemics clearly demand a more vehement reply. Extremism and other challenges to governance that find encouragement from sympathizers, whether in the name of civil society or identity, need a robust response as well. A world of borderless politics also generates its own set of concerns that supplement traditions of influence operations. There are powerful forces with their distinct agenda that encourage the overriding of democratic choices. Their intolerance of anything different is manifested in attempts to delegitimize other points of view. Established newspapers giving UN-sanctioned figures access to their opinion page or eminent broadcasters doing political hatchet jobs are indicative of both a mindset and an objective. That there are many effective tools in play, including the power of technology and influence of civil society organizations, makes this challenge formidable. When it comes to politics, the battle of narratives is a perennial exercise. India has to patiently make the case that its pursuit of national interest is very much in tune with its advocacy of global good. A large part of the answers lies in the world of argumentation and in the effectiveness of communication. Diplomacy, thus, has a responsibility as both the shield and sword of a polity.

Recent global debates about India have implications for our security. As a federal polity of such extraordinary diversity, the quest to nurture the union should be most appreciated in our context. Yet, what we find is that